

Basics of Communication

1.1 Introduction

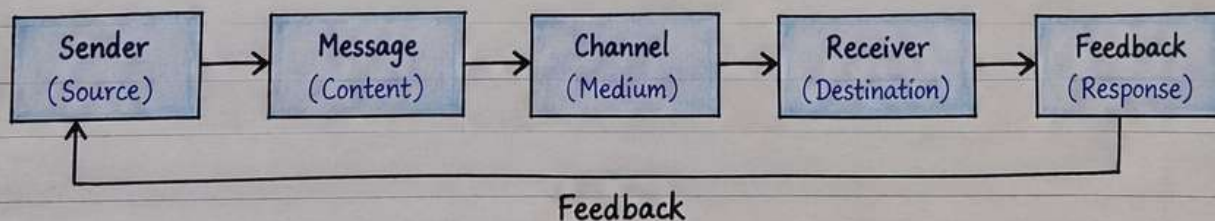
Communication is an essential part of human life. It is the process through which we share our ideas, thoughts, information, feelings and opinions with others. It helps in understanding, building relationships and achieving common goals. Without communication, it would be difficult to live and work together in a society. Communication can be done in various forms such as speaking, writing, listening, gestures or using modern technology like phone, email and internet.

1.2 Definition of Communication

Communication can be defined as the process of exchanging information, ideas, thoughts or feelings between two or more persons with the purpose of creating a common understanding. It involves a sender who transmits the message, a medium or channel through which the message is sent and a receiver who gets the message. According to Oxford Dictionary, communication means "the act of giving, receiving or sharing information". In simple words, communication is a two-way process of sharing and understanding.

1.3 Process of Communication

Communication is not just sending a message, it is a complete process that involves several steps. The process of communication ensures that the message is properly understood by the receiver. It includes the following elements :



1. Sender : The person who has the idea or information and sends the message.
2. Message : The information, ideas or feelings that are to be communicated.
3. Channel : The medium through which the message is transmitted (e.g. speech, letter, phone).
4. Receiver : The person who receives the message.
5. Feedback : The response given by the receiver, which shows whether the message has been understood or not.

Types of Communication - Formal and Informal

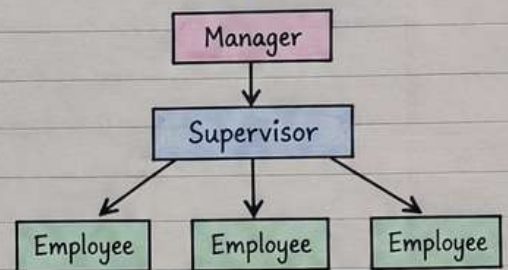
Communication can be classified into different types on the basis of purpose, form, direction and the relationship among people. The two important types are Formal Communication and Informal Communication. Both are necessary in an organisation and serve different purposes.

1. Formal Communication

Formal communication is the official communication that takes place within a specified organisational structure. It follows the rules, policies and hierarchy of the organisation. The message is transmitted through authorized channels and is usually in written form, such as notices, reports, memos, letters and emails. It is goal-oriented and job-related. Formal communication ensures discipline, coordination and proper flow of information in an organisation.

Examples :

- Instructions from a manager to employees.
- Official letters and circulars.
- Reports, meetings and presentations.
- Emails related to work.



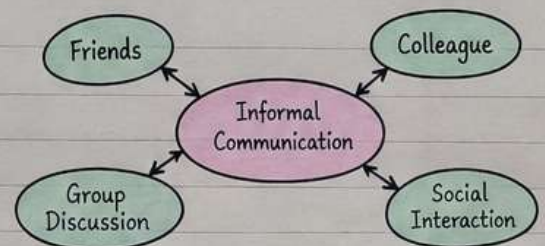
Formal Communication Flow

2. Informal Communication

Informal communication is the unofficial and spontaneous communication that takes place outside the formal structure of an organisation. It arises naturally through personal and social interactions among members. It does not follow any fixed rules or channel. It is usually in oral form, such as casual talks, discussions, gossip or friendly meetings. Informal communication helps in building good relationships, boosting morale and satisfying social needs.

Examples :

- Casual conversation with colleagues.
- Discussion during tea break.
- Sharing information through friends.
- Social media chats among team members.



3. Difference between Formal and Informal Communication

S.No.	Basis	Formal Communication	Informal Communication
1.	Meaning	Official and planned communication.	Unofficial and spontaneous communication.
2.	Channel	Follows organisational hierarchy.	No fixed channel.
3.	Form	Usually written.	Usually oral.
4.	Purpose	Job-related and goal-oriented.	Social and personal.
5.	Relationship	Maintains discipline and coordination.	Builds friendly relations.
6.	Example	Notices, reports, official emails.	Casual talks, gossip, group chats.

Types of Communication - Oral and Written

On the basis of mode of expression, communication can be classified into Oral Communication and Written Communication. Both are widely used in personal, social and professional life. The choice between the two depends on the purpose, situation and the nature of the message.

1. Oral Communication

Oral communication is the process of exchanging information through spoken words. It is the most common and natural form of communication. It includes face-to-face conversations, telephonic calls, speeches, interviews, discussions, meetings and video calls. In oral communication, the message is delivered verbally and the receiver can give immediate feedback. It helps in quick decision making and is useful when personal interaction is possible.

Examples of Oral Communication

- Face-to-face conversation
- Telephone calls
- Speeches and lectures
- Group discussions
- Meetings and interviews
- Video conferencing
- Casual talks



Oral Communication
(Face-to-Face)

2. Written Communication

Written communication is the process of exchanging information through written symbols or text. It includes letters, emails, reports, notices, manuals, messages, etc. It is a more formal and permanent form of communication. Written communication is useful when detailed information is to be shared and when a record is required for future reference. It is widely used in business, education and government organisations.

Examples of Written Communication

- Letters (formal and informal)
- Emails
- Reports
- Notices and circulars
- Text messages
- Manuals and documentation
- Social media posts (written form)



Written Communication
(Letter / Email)

3. Difference between Oral and Written Communication

S.No.	Basis	Oral Communication	Written Communication
1.	Meaning	Exchange of information through spoken words.	Exchange of information through written symbols or text.
2.	Mode	Verbal (speaking and listening).	Written (reading and writing).
3.	Feedback	Immediate feedback possible.	Delayed feedback.
4.	Record	No permanent record.	Provides permanent record.
5.	Formality	Usually informal.	Usually formal.
6.	Suitability	Useful for quick communication.	Useful for detailed information.
7.	Example	Conversation, phone call, speech.	Letter, email, report, notice.

Types of Communication – Verbal and Non-Verbal

Communication can also be classified on the basis of the use of words and body language. In this context, there are two important types : **Verbal Communication** and **Non-Verbal Communication**. Both types work together to make the message more effective and meaningful.

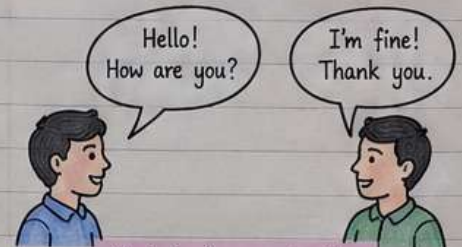
1. Verbal Communication

Verbal communication is the process of exchanging information through words. It includes both spoken and written form of communication. It is the most common and direct way to express ideas, thoughts and feelings. Verbal communication can take place face-to-face, over the telephone, in meetings, through speeches or in written form like letters and emails.

The main advantage of verbal communication is that it allows for clear expression and immediate feedback, especially in oral form. However, the effectiveness of verbal communication depends on the choice of words, tone, language and the listener's understanding.

Examples of Verbal Communication

- Face-to-face conversation
- Telephone calls
- Speeches and lectures
- Meetings and discussions
- Written messages (letters, emails)
- Video conferencing
- Instructions and announcements



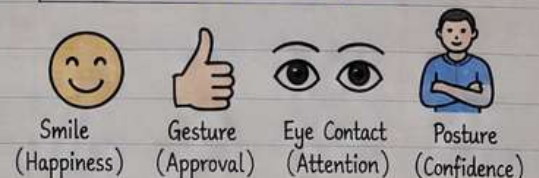
Verbal Communication
(Using Words)

2. Non-Verbal Communication

Non-verbal communication is the process of conveying messages without using words. It includes body language, facial expressions, gestures, posture, eye contact, tone of voice and even silence. Non-verbal communication often supports, complements or sometimes even contradicts verbal messages. It plays an important role in showing emotions and attitudes. For example, a smile can show happiness, a frown can show disapproval, and folded arms may indicate defensiveness. Non-verbal communication is universal and can be understood across different languages and cultures, but its meaning may vary in different contexts.

Examples of Non-Verbal Communication

- Facial expressions (smile, frown)
- Gestures (thumbs up, hand movement)
- Body posture (sitting, standing)
- Eye contact
- Tone of voice (loud, soft)
- Physical appearance (dress, grooming)
- Silence (no response)
- Proxemics (personal space)



3. Difference between Verbal and Non-Verbal Communication

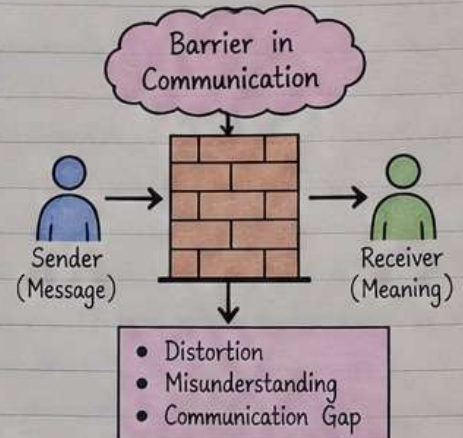
S.No.	Basis	Verbal Communication	Non-Verbal Communication
1.	Meaning	Uses words (spoken or written).	Uses gestures, expressions, etc.
2.	Form	Oral or written.	Visual and behavioural.
3.	Examples	Conversation, speeches, emails.	Facial expressions, gestures, posture.
4.	Feedback	Usually immediate (in oral form).	Often instant and automatic.
5.	Universality	Depends on language.	Generally universal.
6.	Control	Can be planned and controlled.	Often natural and less controlled.
7.	Role	Conveys the actual message.	Supports and enhances the message.

Communication Barriers and How to Overcome Them

Communication is essential for sharing ideas and information, but it is not always smooth. Various barriers can hinder the effective exchange of messages and lead to misunderstanding, confusion and conflict. Understanding these barriers and finding ways to overcome them is important for successful communication in personal, social and professional life.

1. Meaning of Communication Barriers

Communication barriers are the obstacles or difficulties that block, distort or interfere with the transmission and understanding of a message between the sender and the receiver. These barriers can occur at any stage of the communication process and can reduce the effectiveness of communication. As a result, the intended message may not be received correctly, which can lead to errors, dissatisfaction and conflicts.



2. Types of Communication Barriers

Communication barriers can be classified into the following types :

S.No.	Type of Barrier	Explanation	Examples
1.	Physical Barriers	Environmental factors that hinder communication.	Noise, distance, poor lighting, network problems.
2.	Psychological Barriers	Mental state and emotions that affect understanding.	Stress, anger, fear, lack of interest.
3.	Language Barriers	Differences in language or complex words.	Use of technical jargon, different language, poor vocabulary.
4.	Cultural Barriers	Differences in values, beliefs and social norms.	Different traditions, customs, body language.
5.	Organisational Barriers	Barriers within the organisation structure and system.	Rigid hierarchy, lack of proper channels, rules and policies.
6.	Personal Barriers	Individual differences that affect communication.	Lack of confidence, preconceived ideas, ego, poor listening skills.
7.	Technological Barriers	Problems due to communication devices or tools.	Poor internet, technical faults, incompatible software.

3. How to Overcome Communication Barriers

To ensure effective communication, the following measures can be taken :

- Use clear and simple language.
- Be an active listener.
- Reduce noise and other physical disturbances.
- Be open-minded and avoid preconceived notions.
- Use appropriate communication channels.
- Develop cultural awareness and show respect for differences.
- Provide feedback to confirm understanding.
- Use technology effectively and ensure proper tools.
- Build trust and maintain a positive attitude.

Result

- ✓ Better understanding
- ✓ Fewer misunderstandings
- ✓ Stronger relationships
- ✓ Effective teamwork
- ✓ Successful communication

Barriers to Communication

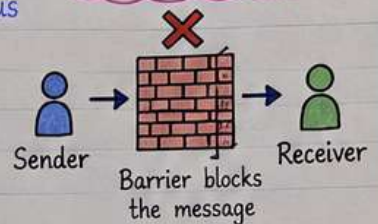
"The single biggest problem in communication is the illusion - that it has taken place."

- George Bernard Shaw

1.1 Meaning of Barriers to Communication

Barriers to communication are the factors or obstacles that hinder the smooth flow of information between the sender and the receiver. These barriers can distort the message, create misunderstanding or prevent the message from reaching its intended goal. Communication may fail completely or partially due to various reasons such as language differences, psychological conditions, physical distance, cultural variations or technical problems. It is important to identify these barriers so that effective communication can be established in personal, professional and social life.

"Good Communication removes barriers and builds better relationships."



1.2 Types of Barriers to Communication

(A) Physical Barriers

Physical barriers are related to the environment or external conditions that prevent effective communication. Examples include noise, distance, poor internet connection, uncomfortable seating, closed doors, etc.

Example : Loud noise in a classroom can make it difficult to hear the speaker clearly.

Examples :

- Noise
- Distance
- Poor infrastructure
- Distractions
- Time constraints

(B) Language Barriers

Language barriers occur when the sender and receiver do not share the same language or have different levels of understanding. Complex words, technical terms and regional languages can also create problems in communication.

Example : A person who does not understand English may find it difficult to follow a lecture delivered in English.

Examples :

- Different language
- Use of difficult words
- Technical jargon
- Different accents
- Poor grammar

(C) Psychological Barriers

Psychological barriers arise due to emotions, attitudes, beliefs and mental state of the individuals. Fear, stress, lack of confidence, prejudice or negative thinking can affect how a message is sent or received.

Example : A person who is angry may misinterpret a simple message as criticism.

Examples :

- Fear and anxiety
- Stress
- Negative attitude
- Lack of confidence
- Prejudice

(D) Cultural Barriers

Cultural barriers occur due to differences in customs, values, traditions and social norms. What is acceptable in one culture may be offensive in another. These differences can lead to misunderstanding and conflict.

Example : A hand gesture that is polite in one country may be considered rude in another.

Examples :

- Different customs
- Different values
- Social norms
- Religious beliefs
- Varied traditions

"Identify the barriers, understand the reason and remove them - for effective communication."